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Open Source Committee Interview Report Summary

Maintainer Retainer Program (MRP)

Following a careful review of the 11 applicants in the second round of the Maintainer Retainer Program (MRP), the Open Source Committee (OSC) selected all 11 individuals for onboarding. During the contract phase, 3 Maintainers chose to step away from the program for personal reasons. This selection process included separate interviews with project teams (when required) to ensure strong alignment and cohesion. Overall, the committee evaluated an exceptionally strong cohort of candidates, characterized by deep technical expertise within the Cardano ecosystem, and a consistent commitment to collaborative, professional open-source contribution.

Andrew Watts (https://github.com/wattsmainsanglais) - *Andamio*
Andrew is a committed community-driven candidate, a full-stack web developer (TypeScript/Node/React, moving into Golang) recognized for his active contributions to Gimbalabs and his ongoing work on Andamio's V1 app and Golang gateway API.

- Technical Profile: Strongest in *TypeScript*, *Node*, *React*, and *Next.js* (the stack most Cardano application work sits on) and deliberately expanding into *Golang*, drawn by *Blink Labs*' work on a *Go* node implementation and the case for diverse node implementations. This places him firmly on the off-chain, tooling, and application side.

- Open Source & Community Enablement: Deeply rooted in open-by-default practice, co-led the Asteria front-end project (based on TxPipe's Asteria project), rewriting its unmaintained off-chain code in Mesh SDK and publishing it as an educational repo, and runs weekly public live-coding sessions that invite others to learn and contribute.

- Code Review & Quality: Systematically reviewed Andamio's gateway API over several weeks and submitted a merged fix preventing internal error details from leaking to clients; his Haskell exposure is limited by his own account, so his strength lies on the off-chain and application side.

Cesar Gomez (https://github.com/zootechdrum) - *Andamio*
Cesar is a capable, all-round engineer with roughly a decade of professional experience, applying a mature web-application background to Cardano through a year of contributions to Andamio's V1 front end, back end, and database layers.

- Technical Depth: Works day-to-day on microservices, keeping type contracts aligned end-to-end across service boundaries; within Cardano he has debugged race conditions between browser wallet extensions and UI state, and drove a wallet-compatibility decision (Eternl/Lace over Typhon/Vespr) on user-experience grounds. Confident in React and Mesh, and open about not having worked at the on-chain/Aiken layer yet.

- Maintainer Practice: Cites unmanaged repos (stale issues, unclear ownership) as the worst of open source, and already counters it by sweeping Andamio's backlog to verify or close aging issues; highly communicative on Discord and able to advance a technical position by argument rather than authority.

Andrew Westberg (https://github.com/AndrewWestberg) - *Oura*
Andrew is an exceptionally strong and deeply established candidate, applying for Aura (TxPipe) on the back of a decade-long track record building core Cardano infrastructure: Jormungandr Manager and CN CLI (the first external tool to implement the node's mini-protocols, delivering leader logs to SPOs a year before IOG's own CLI), whose networking code was later folded into TxPipe's Pallas.

- Technical Depth: Works at the lowest levels of the stack. His hardest problem was reimplementing Amaru's block leadership check in Rust, building a fixed-point big-integer math library from scratch to match the Haskell node exactly to the 34th decimal place, contributed back as pallas-math; he also did the original KES signature implementation in Pallas and routinely submits the patches that keep it current across hard forks and mini-protocol versions.

- Leadership & Community Connection: Led a 15-developer open-source team at NEWM and still actively maintains its newm-chain indexer on donated time; is a maintainer of Daedalus and a contributor to Dolos. His self-described main strength is as a connector (developers across Cardano come to him for direction), reinforced by a Cardano education YouTube channel.

Tsz Wai - (https://github.com/twwu123) - *MeshJS*
Tsz is a deeply technical candidate and key contributor to Mesh SDK: he estimates he wrote roughly 75% of its transaction-building core, having come to Cardano as an Emurgo engineer maintaining the cardano-serialization-lib, which gave him a low-level grasp of how transactions actually work.

- Technical Depth & Design: Deliberately modeled Mesh's TypeScript APIs on cardano-cli so developers could transition without relearning transaction building (a choice validated by educational programs that now teach exactly that path), with the library handling balancing and execution-unit evaluation. Also maintains Mesh's other packages alongside the transaction-building core (wallet, Bitcoin, and a range of utilities), and is open to Rust work (e.g. Pallas) on the strength of his CSL background.

- Review & Quality: The primary reviewer on Mesh; forks each PR, runs the tests, scrutinizes the test cases first (writing additional ones himself where they fall short), and only then reviews the code. Manages codebase sprawl through aggressive refactoring immediately after a first working version.

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Nicholas Clarke (https://github.com/nc6) - *Cardano Base*
Nick is an exceptionally senior candidate with foundational standing in Cardano's core Haskell stack: active since 2018, he wrote the new Byron ledger specification, led the team that implemented the Shelley and Mary ledgers, was previously maintainer of Cardano Base, and served as release manager for Cardano Node, with over ten years of Haskell experience.

- Technical Depth: Designed the era-polymorphic ledger architecture, using Haskell's type system to selectively replace rules per era while preserving older behavior, which remains the basis of how all ledger eras are managed today; also authored Cuddle, the library now used for all CDDL specifications in Cardano. He is direct about his limits: competent at *C* only where it interfaces with *Haskell*, and explicitly not a cryptography specialist, though he has reviewed such code (including as lead reviewer on the KES agent).

- Governance & Fit: Helped establish the original TSC, previously chaired the OSC, and wrote the founding specification for the Security Council, where he still serves. That security work directly informs his choice of Cardano Base: a library he sees as under-attended and one that keeps surfacing in security matters, making it a natural extension of the role he already holds. He has long-standing working relationships with the ledger, network, and formal methods teams, and realistically judges that fast-moving, fully staffed repos (Ledger, Consensus) offer less room for a part-time external maintainer.

Dan Baruka (https://github.com/danbaruka) - *Developer Experience*
Dan is a motivated candidate and current Developer Advocate whose day-to-day language is TypeScript, the reason Evolution SDK is his clear first choice, having spent a month testing the SDK, following its working group sessions, and filing documentation feedback.

- Technical Profile: Builds primarily in TypeScript, with several projects delivered in it, and reports a solid working comprehension of the Evolution SDK codebase and docs from his testing.

- Incident Response: His hardest problem was a live product compromised when a former team member retained push access and force-pushed to main. He traced the commit, confirmed no pending PR explained it, revoked the access, and rolled back to the prior release within two days (an access-control failure he now treats as a permissions-hygiene lesson).

- Maintainer Practice: Disciplined Git workflow (claim the issue first, one branch per issue, iterate through review until the PR meets repo rules); as a reviewer he checks that code actually matches the issue and screens for AI-generated submissions. Prioritizes labelling and grouping the backlog, coaching contributors through issues, and fixing critical bugs fast. Brings prior team-lead experience as a CTO and roughly four years of working in development teams.

Evgenii Lisitskii (https://github.com/lisicky) - *MeshJS*
Eugene is a strong low-level candidate for Mesh SDK, working primarily on its transaction builder and providers, and is among the heaviest contributors to the *cardano-serialization-lib*, giving him deep, practical knowledge of how Cardano transactions are built and debugged.

- Technical Depth: Works mainly in Rust and TypeScript, the stack most Cardano tooling is built on, with earlier experience in *C#* and other languages; reads *Haskell* well enough to trace Cardano validation rules and debug at the node level, though he doesn't write it. Approaches hard problems by isolating root cause, decomposing the issue, and choosing between a workaround, an upstream contribution, or a fork.

- Contributor Enablement: Puts documentation first (a clear entry point, expected code quality, and how to prepare a PR), so most contributor questions are answered before they are asked, with Discord and GitHub issues as the fallback. Where upstream maintainers are unresponsive, he publishes a fork and points others to it rather than letting the fix stall.

- Conflict Resolution: Lays out the trade-offs of each option side by side and tries to synthesize a solution that satisfies all parties; where someone holds firm, he grounds the decision in real constraints (time, resources) rather than opinion. His examples came largely from closed-source work, so he described his approach more than specific open-source cases.

Sandeep Sooryaprakash (https://github.com/sandykwl) - *Plutonomicon Plutarch-Plutus*
Sandeep is a seasoned backend engineer with 15 years of professional experience and five years in Cardano, currently working full-time on a Cardano project, with hands-on command of both smart contract development and Rust-based off-chain tooling.

- Contribution Quality: His contributions show maintainer instincts: on finding a semantic flaw in an existing library API, he filed an issue and added corrected functions rather than overriding the originals, preserving backward compatibility and recommending deprecation of the old ones; separately, he picked up a "help wanted" issue for missing unit test coverage and seeded a PR, checking the format with the team so it could be built on.

- Debugging & Support: Cites the absence of a usable stack trace when a smart contract fails after off-chain integration as Cardano's hardest development problem, and works through it by line-by-line isolation. When a library upgrade broke his project, he built and documented a minimal reproducible use case for the maintainers, which let them locate the regression and cover it with a test.

- Profile & Perspective: Recognized with hackathon awards at the Cardano Summit in Berlin and a Charli3 hackathon. Frames open source less as a preference than a necessity for Cardano's sustainability.

Emmanuel Titi Shikuku (https://github.com/Emmanuel-Tyty) - *Cardano Node Emulator*
Emmanuel is a developer-advocate-minded candidate with four years building dApps and smart contracts in Cardano, whose strongest asset is bringing new contributors into repositories. Around ten months of active open source work backing an application spanning Rust and Haskell projects.

- Contributor Onboarding: His clearest contribution is recruitment and facilitation: he onboarded two community members from working group sessions into a core repository and brokered the communication between them and the maintainer. He guards against wasted effort by first confirming with maintainers that an issue is still relevant and prioritized, having seen too many PRs sit unreviewed for years.

- Contribution Track Record: Comfortable in Rust (self-taught since late last year, with an open source project and merged contributions to TxPipe repositories), and actively learning Haskell as a deliberate career direction. He landed a feature PR by iterating through maintainer feedback, and built enough rapport to be invited into their weekly sessions.

- Judgment & Reflection: Resolved a cross-team conflict on a Cardano Foundation platform, where an undocumented architectural requirement caused significant rework, by bringing all parties into one room and asking directly what else had not been shared. He is also self-critical in a useful way: having chased a maintainer over Discord for two weeks to get a PR reviewed, he now advises discussing intent in the project's central forum before writing code.

Emmanuel Mutisya (https://github.com/emmanuel-musau) - EvolutionSDK
Emmanuel is a Cardano application developer with three years in the ecosystem, formerly with the Lidonation team and now building a smart contract project. He arrives as a daily consumer of Cardano's open source tooling seeking to cross the line from user to maintainer.

- Technical Profile: Works primarily in TypeScript, using Mesh core day-to-day for wallet connections and transaction building and submission, and the Cardano CLI for transactions and smart contract work. Limited Haskell exposure. He frames his value as bringing the working user's perspective back into the projects to improve developer experience.

- Support & Documentation: Identifies documentation and code review as the parts of open source he values most: documentation because everyone benefits, review because it spreads skill and catches bugs before production. Onboards new contributors by supplying context and reviewing code alongside them, escalating to core maintainers where his own understanding runs out.

- Conflict Resolution: Begins by establishing the shared goal, then puts every proposed option on the table and weighs each against that goal, escalating to a more experienced colleague when no consensus emerges. A structured approach, though he described it in the abstract rather than through a specific case.

Harun Mwangi (https://github.com/HarunJr)- *Plutus*
Harun is a well-rounded ecosystem contributor with 8–9 years of software development experience and four years in Cardano. Currently, a smart contract developer at *Anastasia Labs* working on *Midgard*, and an Intersect Developer Advocate for the past eight months.

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- Technical Range: Strong in TypeScript, including the *Effect* framework, having been part of the team behind *Lucid Evolution* before it moved into Intersect; proficient in *Aiken*, where he led open source work on a payment subscription contract and an upgradeable multisig.

- Maintainer Practice: Treats responsiveness as the core duty, never leaving a tagged PR hanging, since silence signals an unmaintained repo. His stated hardest ongoing problem is precisely the inverse: thoroughly reviewed PRs whose authors then vanish. He resolves these by triaging on priority, finishing critical ones himself or reassigning them, and closing nice-to-haves.

- Documentation & Community: Has written extensively for the ecosystem, including *Lucid Evolution* docs and *Aiken* design patterns, and values documentation work for keeping his own understanding current. Resolves conflict by seeking majority consensus and is comfortable folding when outvoted (his priority being to move forward rather than stall).

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Conclusion:

The second MRP cohort marks the programme's shift from proposal to operating institution, with a wider applicant pool, a working interview and scoring process, resolved contracting, and monthly milestones reported publicly on-chain through Andamio. The interviews showed why continuity matters: maintenance has no completion date, and this cohort includes libraries that had lost their caretakers, repositories resting on a single person, and critical indexers sustained on donated time.

Appendix: OSC Members completed scoring primarily at the Interview stage for the second round. The absence of graphics should not be interpreted to mean less of a review, yet a more focused approach to evaluating each developer alongside their presented skillsets.